

risk are you for missing that release? At what point does this escalate to higher management?

- How do you currently manage auditing and compliance with your existing software development toolchain?

- How easy or difficult is it for you to pull together audit evidence and proof points across multiple tools? How could you benefit from a faster process?

- How do you collect the data for security and compliance on a regular basis? When you have a breach, what are the implications and who has to get involved? What type of information is required? How long does it take for your teams to provide audit evidence?

- GitLab Premium includes several enhancements that help with auditing and compliance including the below (see the [Why GitLab Premium?](#) page for value descriptions of each of these features)

- Audit Logs - Review changes by user and track access

- Auditor users - Read-only access to all projects, groups, and other resources on the GitLab instance

- Merge Request Reviews - Draft multiple comments in a merge request code review and review/resolve comments together

- Verified Committer - Ensure only authorized and verified team members are allowed to commit to the project

- Require Signed Commits - Enforce policy to require signed commits from contributors

Discovery Questions for GitLab Ultimate

Overview

GitLab Ultimate helps organizations increase operational efficiencies, deliver better products faster, and reduce security and compliance risk. This product tier is ideal for projects with executive visibility and strategic organizational usage and helps enterprises transform IT by optimizing and accelerating delivery while managing priorities, security, risk, and compliance. Ultimate helps organizations achieve advanced DevOps maturity. Are these capabilities important to your customer? Consider asking the below questions to find out.

Security

- To what degree is cybersecurity a critical concern for you and your organization?

- How would you characterize the actions your organization is taking to ensure all applications are secure?

- What challenges have or do you run into as it relates to securing all applications?

- GitLab Ultimate weaves security into the pipeline to provide early and actionable feedback to the development team and includes the following security features:

- Static Application Security Testing (SAST) - Evaluates the static code, checking for potential security issues

- Dynamic Application Security Testing (DAST) - Analyzes the review application to identify potential security issues

- Dependency Scanning - Evaluates the third-party dependencies to identify potential security issues

- Container Scanning - Analyzes Docker images and checks for potential security issues

- Security Dashboard - Visualize the latest security status for each project and across projects

- Security Metrics and Trends (future) - Metrics and historical data about how many vulnerabilities have been spotted, addressed, solved, and how much time was spent for the complete cycle

Compliance

- How important is license compliance to your organization so that you can track project dependencies for their licenses and approve or deny specific licenses?
- GitLab Ultimate offers the following compliance features:
 - License Compliance - Identify the presence of new software licenses included in your project. Approve or deny the inclusion of a specific license
 - Compliance Templates - Templates to streamline audit management with specific regulatory standards. Currently, HIPAA is available. SOX & SOC2 are in the near term roadmap.

Project Insights

- How would it affect your organization's efficiencies to gain insights into things that matter for your projects (e.g. triage hygiene, issues created/closed per a given period, average time for merge requests to be merged, etc.)?
- If this is of interest, position Project Insights

Portfolio Management

- What does your organization do today to track software development and delivery projects from start to finish?
- How easy or difficult is it to provide senior leadership with end to end visibility of these projects?
- How would it affect productivity if everyone involved in critical projects had a common view of portfolio planning, tracking, and execution in one tool?
- GitLab Ultimate delivers robust portfolio management that enables this end-to-end insight and visibility to help your organization focus on delivering business value. Highlighted features include:
 - Multi Level Epics - Organize, plan, and prioritize business ideas and initiatives
 - VSM Workflow Analytics (future) - Visualize the end to end value stream to identify and resolve bottlenecks
 - Risk Management (future) - Manage risk of epics not being completed on time
 - What-If Scenario Planning (future) - Visualize potential impact in the overall portfolio if you were to make a change
 - Roadmap Capacity Planning (future) - Visualize if future work is feasible from an effort perspective

Other

- Guest users - Guest users don't count towards the license count

ADDITIONAL QUESTIONS IF·

Prospect Signed Up For a Free Trial (goal: ensure a successful trial)

- How would you and your organization describe a successful trial?
- What are the most important criteria in your evaluation?
- How many users are you interested in deploying on GitLab?
- Are you evaluating any other tools?
- What is your timeframe for making a decision?

- Are you looking to bring one division of your company on to EE?
- If only a group, what is preventing you from bringing on the entire company at this time?

Competing/Selling Against GitHub and GitHub Actions

- Review the battle card and discovery questions here

Competing/Selling Against Microsoft Azure DevOps

- Review the battle card and discovery questions here

Competing/Selling against BitBucket

- Review the battle card and discovery questions here

Customer is Using Jira

- How would you describe the current implementation of Jira within your organization?
- What are some of the challenges you have with Jira (if any)?

Post Sale Account Development

Goal: Understand why they bought and use nuggets to further expand the sale and help with other sales

- How is the adoption of GitLab going?
- What are you liking about GitLab EE?
- What are you not liking or have questions about?
- How has GitLab helped your group? What are their use cases?
 - Improve code quality?
 - Speed up code releases?
- How many projects do they have?
- Is there anything you or your team would like to see within GitLab?
- Are you seeing any challenges with not having other groups using GitLab as well?
- Are there other groups that you think would benefit using GitLab?
- If yes, how would you suggest getting in contact with them?
- How many of the provisioned licenses are being used?
- If low adoption, Is there anything I can do to help you?
- If high adoption of licenses, Ask what their growth plans are and when they feel they will need to increase their seats?
- Would you be willing to be a reference customer for GitLab? If so, how has GitLab helped you and your organization?

SECTION: sales/revenue-programs.md

Overview

The purpose of GitLab's Revenue Program is to improve the quantity of opportunities and closed

business with defined, cross-functional sales motions to ultimately generate more ARR for GitLab. This objective is achieved through a managed series of coordinated, cross-functional activities to address a specific pipeline gap with a specific pipeline goal, over a set period of time.

How to Generate More ARR

- Create More Pipeline - Efforts focus on using data and informed industry information to identify routes to market that have the highest propensity to buy, while ensuring the value proposition and messaging align with the clients goals & objectives.
- Increase Deal Sizes - Efforts focus on understanding client buying and expansion behaviors in order to optimize individual sales cycles.
- Improve the Velocity and Accuracy in Closing Deals - Efforts focus on enabling the CRO teams with the skills needed to uncover customer pain points, conduct discoveries, create value for the customer and close business with greater efficiency.

What are Value Plays

A prescribed, structured set of steps or activities that field team members & partners follow to deliver a customer solution (product or suite of products & services that business purchase to solve business problems). Value plays are solutions to the value drivers that organizations are looking to achieve. Attributes of a good value play include, but are not limited to:

- A defined and manageable list of accounts/prospects
- An ideal customer profile and target personas
- Customer challenges & solution overview
- Industry & market trends
- Discovery questions & objection handling
- GitLab differentiators & proof points
- Supporting partners and services offerings
- A call to action or high value offer

SECTION: sales/sales-meetings.md

The below page overviews the primary all-hands meetings for the WW Field Team.

Field All-Hands Meetings

The team meets as a full group multiple times in a given quarter, with each meeting series serving a different enablement or planning purpose.

The high-level cadence of Field all-hands meetings in a given quarter is:

1. Month 1
 1. WW Field Manager Call
 1. Quarterly Business Reviews (QBRs)
1. Month 2
 1. WW Field Org Call

1. Month 3

1. No all-hands meeting; quiet time for end-of-quarter activities.

WW Field Manager Call

- When: Quarterly in the first month of each quarter. The call is 50 minutes.
- The call recording is shared with Japan/APAC managers once available with a CTA to watch the prepared remarks (watching the Q&A is not required). The CRO then leads a dedicated follow-up Japan/APAC Manager Q&A session 1-3 business days after the initial call.
- Who: All Field Managers (people managers and above in the CRO's organization), People Business Partners supporting the Field, Sales Development Management
- What: The goal of this meeting is to provide manager-specific updates, CTAs and enablement topics, and to give managers a forum to provide feedback and ask questions to senior leaders.

The sample call format is:

1. [5 min] Manager Icebreaker
1. [10 min] CRO Business Update
 1. Past quarter themes (to the extent we can share before earnings)
 1. Past quarter key win
 1. Observations on pipe gen & forecasts
 1. Current quarter focuses/themes (ex. Current quarter pipe coverage - here are the levers to pull)
1. Current quarter OKR preview
1. Board meeting insights
1. Top investments
1. [20 min] Flex Time
 1. Guest speaker (enablement on manager-specific topic or skill)
 1. Field manager spotlight
 1. Manager feedback
1. [15 min] Q&A
1. [Async] Your help needed: Cross-functional updates

Quarterly Business Reviews

QBRs commence in the final week of the previous quarter for Customer Success and continue into the second or third week of the current quarter for Sales, with the CRO LT completing the QBR cycle.

For a full overview of the QBR planning and execution process, QBR request tracking, best-practices for organizers and attendees, and where to find past QBR content, see [here](#).

WW Field Org Call

- When: Quarterly in the second month of each quarter. Typically on a Monday or Tuesday in the morning PT for 50 minutes.
- The call recording is shared with Japan/APAC team members once available with a CTA to watch the prepared remarks (watching the Q&A is not required). The CRO then leads a dedicated follow-up Japan/APAC Q&A session 1-3 business days after the initial call.
- Who: This meeting includes all members of the CRO organization as well as stakeholders of the Field team from the Marketing, Finance, Legal and People Groups.
- If you are in the Field organization and do not have the calendar invite, first confirm

that your manager has opened a role-based access request to add you to your team's Google Group (ex. sales-ent). Field attendance is informed by the sales-all Google Group, which is made up of all team sub-groups. Using this method, the calendar invite will auto-add new team members to the invite once they're added to their group.

- If you are not in the Field organization, reach out in sales-vp to be added to this meeting series,

- What: The primary purpose of the call is to drive knowledge-sharing across the Field organization, with an emphasis on CRO and leadership business/organizational updates and Q&A time for Field team members and leadership. The typical format is:

1. [20-30 min] CRO Organizational Update

1. High-priority topics/announcements from the CRO and CRO LT

1. Quarterly MVP recognition

1. CRO Fireside Chat/interview

1. [5-10 min] Guest Speaker Updates

1. [15-20 min] Q&A

1. Update Ticker (included asynchronously)

- If you would like to add topics to the agenda, please coordinate with Field Communications using their announcement request process.

General Guidelines for Attendees

1. This call is most effective when we all contribute! Please ask questions in the Q&A using the Slido link provided in the agenda doc.

1. Any updates or Q&A questions that are not covered on the call will be addressed asynchronously in the agenda. Please read the agenda in full each time, including the important updates in the async Update Ticker.

1. The agenda can be found in the meeting calendar invite.

1. Zoom recording links for past calls are included inline in the agenda document under the meeting date.

1. If you cannot join the call, consider reviewing the recorded call, or at minimum, read through the meeting agenda.

1. If you have feedback on how we can improve the WW Field Org Call, share it in the post-meeting survey provided via Zoom when you log off the call.

Enablement/Planning/Strategy Meetings

Field Enablement Spotlight series

- When: Weekly on Thursday at 9am Pacific time, except in the last two weeks of a quarter

- Who: The entire GitLab Field team is invited to this meeting series. The series can be found on the Field Enablement Google Calendar.

- What: The purpose of this series is to enable Field team members on the latest resources and selling tactics. Enablement topics vary weekly. See more on the handbook page.

Sales Group Conversation

- When: Happens once every 8 weeks at 8am Pacific time

- Where: Zoom link varies - please be sure to check the calendar invitation

- What: The CRO Leaders will rotate and provide the company with an update on their business, overall team performance, notable wins, accomplishments, and relevant strategies planned.

You can view previous updates in the "Group Conversation Sales" (previously "Functional Group Update Sales") folder on the Google Drive.

Sales Monthly Key Review

- When: Happens once every month
- Where: Zoom link varies - please check the calendar invitation
- What: Michael McBride (CRO) will present to the CEO, CFO, and other company leaders a monthly Sales update.

This update will include the current status of:

- Sales KPI's
- OKR's

The meeting will cover:

- the quarterly forecast
- QTD performance
- most recent month's performance

We will provide key takeaways as to what is on-track (green), needs improvement (yellow), or is of urgent concern (red).

We will review the standard IACV/ARR look back on historical performance, as well as the Pipeline X-Ray, which includes future-looking metrics like pipeline generation, coverage, and pacing for the current and next quarters.

Focus Fridays

The Field team practices Focus Fridays. The goal is to encourage all field team members to clear out their calendars on Fridays as much as possible in hopes that this will help all of us be more efficient, allow space within our weeks for focused work, and reduce potential burnout. Guidance for Focus Fridays includes:

- Cancel or move any standing meetings occurring on Fridays
- Customer/prospect/partner/external meetings are exceptions
- Some one-off internal meetings might not be avoidable, but aim to minimize them as much as possible
- Consider blocking off your calendar as "busy" on Fridays to block your work time

You are encouraged to talk to your manager for guidance on how best to embrace Focus Fridays on your team and with your individual schedule.

SECTION: sales/sales-renewal-process.md

Please see the Go To Market - Renewals Internal Handbook Page

SECTION: sales/selling-professional-services.md

Please see the Internal Sales Definitions Document

SECTION: sales/shadow-program.md

Overview

Shadowing the customer calls of your peers offers a hands-on way to learn how different GitLab roles represent GitLab. We often learn best when we have the opportunity to learn from our peers, practice, and get feedback in an interactive way. It's also a great way to make new hires feel welcome and a part of our sales culture at GitLab.

A good shadow program creates a culture of curiosity and peer-to-peer learning that increases productivity and confidence, while decreasing time to ramp. The Customer Ready Shadow Program begins with a training in GitLab LevelUp that shows participants:

- how the program works and the benefits of participating,
 - how to be a good shadow or host one yourself,
 - how shadows achieve certification,
- and how to get started shadowing or hosting.

By participating, everyone can:

- Develop stronger relationships with your peers across the globe while creating and contributing to a positive sales culture at GitLab.
- Strengthen your skills through the experience of sharing them with others. After all, the way you go about something in your territory or country may be different from the way someone in another country may go about it.

Getting started

Start as soon as you begin onboarding. Shadows can begin shadowing immediately after taking the introduction training. As a shadow, new hires benefit from a stronger understanding of the customer: hearing in real-time what they're looking for, what their pain points are, and how GitLab may be able to help. As a shadow, you'll also:

- See how your peers position and frame solutions to current and potential customers and spot opportunities to learn from or improve those interactions
- Hear ideas, questions, challenges, and concerns directly from customers and prospects
- Collaborate with your peers and get feedback on your approach
- And apply all your knowledge to the test in a real pitch scenario.

Onboarding buddies: A big part of an onboarding buddy's responsibility is offering calls to shadow or connecting the new hire with peers that can offer calls to shadow.

Hosts: A person hosting a call and inviting the new hire to it is a 'Host'. They invite new hires to customers calls, provide them with a link to the opportunity, and may also brief or debrief with the new hires before or after the call. Hosting is a great opportunity to:

- Create and contribute to a positive sales culture at GitLab
- Expand your coaching skillset, simply by having someone shadow you live.
- A great way to show your ready to take on more responsibility whether through a promotion or job title change

Managers: Managers should be familiar with the program when they assign an onboarding buddy to their new hire. They can take the introduction training to learn more about it, and will receive updates throughout the program. It's the manager's role to ultimately ensure the new hire is getting enough calls to shadow and receiving support from their peers. A manager will also grade the new hire's pitch at the end of the program so they can achieve certification.

Shadow etiquette

Shadow etiquette is one of the most important parts of being a shadow or having one. Adhering to it builds trust in the program, but also with each other. And the relationships you build now will deliver benefits long after the program is over.

What is shadow etiquette? These are your rules of engagement with each other. They can change at any time but they should always be communicated before they change. Below are the expected rules of engagement that both people should start from.

View the introduction training (link coming soon) to learn the basic expectations you should start from when shadowing or hosting.

What to look for on calls

Not every call is a hit. And you may attend calls where it goes really well or poorly for multiple reasons. Use your time in these calls to determine for yourself what works well and what doesn't with customers and prospects. Challenge your assumptions and that of the customer or even the host.

This is your chance to sit back and put on your critical-thinking hat. As you go through the rest of your training, compare what you've learned to what you're seeing and decide what you want to improve as you prepare to take the stage yourself.

Graduating from the program

At some point during onboarding, new hires are invited to a weekly series with their peers where they'll share and learn from each other, hear advice and lessons learned from tenured SAEs, and even customers. This looks different for different segments, and may run at different times depending on your start date. If this is relevant to you, you'll receive an invite from your sales enablement lead and attending will be part of your certification.

Certification: The program completes with a pitch review where new hires record themselves presenting the One Platform story. This is also a key part of graduating from the overall onboarding journey and usually occurs at the end of the new hire's first 90 days. This

recording is graded by a manager and a passing score must be achieved to graduate. Once shadows graduate from this program, they'll achieve the coveted Customer-Ready certification badge.

View additional resources on GitLab LevelUp (coming soon) or reach out in the customer-ready-shadow-program channel.

SECTION: sales/sop.md

This page has been deprecated and moved to Business Operations

SECTION: sales/tam.md

Please see the Sales Handbook Definitions Doc

SECTION: sales/territory-planning.md

Overview

Every Account Executive regardless of segment or geo should have a plan for how they're approaching their patch. A sales territory plan is a workable plan for targeting the right customers and implementing goals for income and consistent sales growth over time.

It's usually done annually and updated throughout the year. It can be used for plotting a specific geographical location, or for different industries, customer types and other segments.

When do you need one? Some AEs might be starting up a whole new territory and need a detailed, comprehensive plan, whereas others may be one of several AEs operating in their territory and may benefit from a narrower plan. The key is that you have a plan documented to reach your goals.

Why it matters

Benjamin Franklin once said, "If you fail to plan, you are planning to fail."

A clear plan reflects clear thinking and a clear road to success. Your territory plan is a living document that you'll go back to again and again to update. Use it in your strategy meetings to communicate your goals and approach with your team, and to bring them along on your vision so they can contribute effectively. Use it to help you keep track of how you're doing against your goals over time.

Keeping your plan up-to-date will also save you time during reporting, forecasting, and quarterly business reviews as a lot of the content can be reused. As well as during performance reviews when you can easily look back on your progress as a reference point.

Crafting a plan like this involves more work and effort upfront, but gets easier over time. Be sure to dedicate time to doing it right. After all, delivering a plan like this one is a core element of what it means to be a strategic account leader.

During the planning process you will:

- Analyze territory, pipeline, and account data.
- Identify internal and external factors that can affect your plan.
- Identify strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats operating in your territory.
- Set goals and create targets.
- Analyze and prioritize your accounts.
- Develop strategies and action plans to reach your goals and targets.
- Review and track your results.

View the internal handbook to access the Territory Planning Toolkit and to get started on your plan.

SECTION: sales/understand-customer-gitlab-use.md

This page contains guidance to help you better understand how our customers are using GitLab so that you can be more prepared and informed in customer conversations.

Adoption - GitLab Usage Statistics

Using GitLab Version Check, GitLab usage data is pushed into Salesforce for both CE, EE and EE trial users.

Once in Salesforce application, you will see a tab called "Usage Statistics".

Using the drop down view, you can select CE, EE trails or EE to see all usage data sent to GitLab.

Since version check is pulling the host name, the lead will be recorded as the host name. Once you have identified the correct company name, please update the company name.

Example: change gitlab.boeing.com to Boeing as the company name.

To view the usage, click the hyperlink under the column called "Usage Statistics".

The link will consist of several numbers and letters like, a3p61012001a002.

You can also access usage statistics on the account object level within Salesforce.

Within the account object, there is a section called "Usage Ping Data", which will contain the same hyperlink as well as a summary of version they are using, active users, historical users, license user count, license utilization % and date data was sent to us.

A few example of how to use Usage Statistics to pull insight and drive action?

- If prospecting into CE users, you can sort by active users to target large CE instances. You can see what they are using within GitLab, like issues, CI build, deploys, merge requests, boards, etc. You can then target your communications to learn how they are using GitLab internally and educate them on what is possible with EE.
- For current EE users who are below their license utilization, you can engage the customer to

understand their plan to rollout GitLab internally and how/where we can help them with adoption.

- For current EE users who are above their license utilization, you can leverage the data to engage the customer.

Celebrate the adoption of GitLab within their organization. Ask why the adoption took off?

How they are using it (use cases)? Engage them in amending their contract right now for the add-on?

Update the renewal opportunity to reflect the increase in usage for the true-up and new renewal amount.

- For current EE users who are not using a EE feature, i.e. CI or issues, you can engage the customer to understand why they are not using it.

Do they know we offer it?

Are they using a competitive tool?

Have they integrated their current tool into GitLab?

Are they open to learning more about what we offer to replace their current tool?

- For EE trials.

What EE features are they using and not using?

If using a EE feature, what are they trying to solve and evaluate?

If not using, why and are they open to evaluating that feature?

Take a look at a Training Video to explain in greater detail by searching for the "Sales Training" folder on the Google Drive.

Open Source users - GitLab CE Instances and CE Active Users on SFDC Accounts

In an effort to make the Usage/Version ping data simpler to use in SFDC, there are 2 fields directly on the account layout - "CE Instances" and "Active CE Users" under the "GitLab/Tech Stack Information" section on the Salesforce account record.

The source of these fields is to use the latest version ping record for and usage record for each host seen in the last 60 days and combine them into a single record.

The hosts are separated into domain-based hosts and IP-based hosts.

For IP based hosts, we run the IP through a reverse-DNS lookup to attempt to translate to a domain-based host.

If no reverse-DNS lookup (PTR record) is found, we run the IP through a whois lookup and try to extract a company name, for instance, if the IP is part of a company's delegated IP space.

We discard all hosts that we are unable to identify because they have a reserved IP address (internal IP space) or are hosted in a cloud platform like GCP, Alibaba Cloud, or AWS as there is no way to identify those organizations through this data.

For domain-based hosts, we use the Datafox &/or DiscoverOrg domain lookup API to identify the company and firmographic data associated with the organization and finally the Google Geocoding API to parse, clean, and standardize the address data as much as possible.

These stats will be aggregated up and only appear on the Ultimate Parent account in SFDC when there are children (since we don't really know which host goes to which child).

To see a list of accounts by of CE users or instances, you can use the CE Users list view in SFDC.

To filter for just your accounts, hit the "edit" button and Filter for "My Accounts".

Make sure to save it under a different name so you don't wipe out the original.

These fields are also available in SFDC reporting.

A few caveats about this data:

- The hosts are mapped based on organization name, domain, and contact email domains to relate the instances to SFDC accounts as accurately as possible, but we may occasionally create false associations.

Let the Data & Analytics team know when you find errors or anomalies.

- Both fields can be blank, but the organization can still be a significant CE user.

Both fields being blank just means that there are no instances sending us version or usage pings, not necessarily that there are no active instances.

- Users can be the same person in multiple instances, so if a user exists in several instances at an organization with the usage ping on, they are counted each time they appear in an instance.

Users may also be external to an organization, so the number of users may not represent employees and can thus be higher than the number of employees.

- These numbers represent the minimum amount that GitLab is likely being used within the organization, since some instances may have these pings turned on and some off.

They also may have just the version ping on, in which case we won't see the number of users.

This should not be interpreted as having instances but no users.

For the process of working these accounts, appending contacts from third-party tools, and reaching out, please refer to the business operations section of the handbook.

Use Case Technology Tracking

The goal of this process is to capture information about the technology an Account in Salesforce (by way of Gainsight) uses in each Use Case of their DevOps Tools landscape. This will allow us to market & sell to specific stages in their CI/CD process more accurately.

Please enter the following data in the "White Space (Use Case)" section of a specific Account in Gainsight:

- uc(Use Case) Tech: Current technology used by prospect/customer (Including GitLab)
- uc(Use Case) Appetite for Replacement: Red (Don't want to change), Yellow (Might change) /Green (Willing to change)
- uc(Use Case) Contract End Date: As exact as possible date their current technology contract end

See the License Usage Handbook for more information.

SECTION: sales/account-planning/_index.md

Overview

An account plan is a document or record that contains important details about a customer or prospect, including information about the organization's business, strategic objectives, mission-critical priorities, goals and motivations, competitive landscape, pertinent technology

stack details, key contacts and relationship maps, and the Account Executive's strategy and action plan over varying time horizons (6 months, 12 months, 18 months) to establish and expand a mutually beneficial, long-term strategic relationship.

The AE should think about account planning as if they were the CEO of their own territory. If you were a CEO, what information would you need to give banks, investors, or employees to demonstrate that you have a viable business plan that you can execute? An account plan is a business plan that helps the team analyze and execute on the business with a specific account. Like a CEO, the SAE need a leadership team to effectively plan for the account. Be sure to leverage the Solutions Architect, Customer Success Manager, Renewal Managers and Channel Partners as you strategize and build the account plan!

Get started with the Account Planning template in our shared Google Drive (internal team members only).

Why Account Planning?

Account planning helps the AE and the larger account team elevate opportunity-driven conversations into value-based conversations that focus on the customer's value drivers. Good account plans help the team focus on what matters to earn strategic partner status with the customer which, in turn, will drive increased share of wallet and predictable growth. Account planning is NOT about creating a report for management--it's about helping the team create a strategic plan for long-term customer growth and retention.

An effective account plan defines a clear strategy and action plan to grow and expand customer relationships and will help the AE and the team:

- Better understand the customer's financial health, market position, strategic objectives, risks, key partners, tech stack, relationships with other DevOps vendors, and more
- Prioritize pursuits based on where GitLab can alleviate challenges and pain points that the customer is currently experiencing that are getting in the way of reaching desired business outcomes
- Assess the "health" of relationships within the account (access to power, strength of champions, breadth of relationships across lines of business, etc.)
- Identify resources and/or support needed to successfully execute against strategic account objectives and supporting action plans
- Determine risks and developing proactive risk mitigation plans

What is the Difference Between an Account Plan and a Success Plan?

The account plan focuses on the account team's strategy to win, retain, and expand the partnership and business relationship with key customers. Success plans, on the other hand, clearly document what and how GitLab will deliver value throughout the customer lifecycle to help the customer optimize their return on investment and achieve specific business objectives aligned to the value drivers in the account plan. Success plans and the associated outcomes can also help inform and validate the account plan.

What is the Difference Between an Account Plan and an Opportunity Plan?

The opportunity plan (aka the Command Plan) outlines the strategy for closing business related

to a single budgeted customer initiative. In contrast, the account plan is a more comprehensive, holistic, organization-wide strategy and action plan for earning the trust and respect of the customer. This is achieved by delivering value to the customer over and over again. Unlike opportunity plans, account plans span multiple customer engagements and lines of business across the account over a longer period of time and may include actions that don't directly align to revenue (e.g. customer appreciation initiatives, other).

Components of an Account Plan

There are a few different components that are part of an account plan.

1. Account Profile
1. Relationship and Influence Mapping
1. Whitespace Mapping
1. Action Plan

Account Profile

Basic account details should already be entered into Salesforce. The purpose of the Account Profile section of the account plan is to capture important details about the customer or prospect, including information about the organization's business, strategic objectives, goals and motivations, competitive landscape, pertinent technology stack details, and more. The account profile is all about the customer (not GitLab).

Start at a high level, for example:

1. What are the organization's goals and the prioritized strategic initiatives aligned to each goal? What value drivers are most important and why?
1. What macro environment factors are affecting the organization (e.g. market conditions, competition, regulatory and compliance changes, etc.) and what impact and implications do these factors have on the organization's business strategy?
1. Who are the organization's primary competitors and how does the organization plan to maintain and/or grow market share?
1. What are the biggest risks facing the organization (for short, medium, and longer term time horizons) that may get in the way of the customer achieving their goals?
1. How does the organization's IT department and/or strategy support (or hinder) the above strategic objectives or initiatives?
1. What is the organization's digital transformation strategy and how does that support the strategic business objectives?
1. What is the perception of how IT is enabling and/or hindering progress against these strategic business objectives?
1. How does the customer currently view GitLab? How long have they been a customer? What is their annual spend with GitLab? For what DevOps stages does the customer use GitLab today and where have expansion opportunities already been identified?

Relationship and Influence Mapping

Mapping the org (multi-threading) allows us to analyze where we are strong and where we have vulnerabilities which will drive some of our actions later in the plan. Relationship mapping includes but is not limited to assessing:

- The breadth and depth of relationship "coverage" within an account (both within and across lines of business)
- Access to power, champions, and key influencers
- The strength or health of key relationships (identify which contacts are promoters, detractors, or somewhere in between)
- How different parts of the organization engage with and/or influence each other. This can be independent of reporting structure.
- Who and what has influence over key contacts in the account (e.g. specific analysts, partners, events, trade publications, user groups, other)

If the account plan is with an existing customer, Net Promoter Score (NPS) data may provide helpful insights into and help track relationship health and trends.

As the AE builds and continues to refine the account plan, consider the following:

- What existing relationships does the team need to continue to nurture and strengthen?
- What new relationships does the team need to establish, why, and how will we do it?
- Who is a GitLab champion, potential champion, detractor?
- Who are the champions and detractors for the primary competitors in the account?
- What is each person's level of influence and their professional/career trajectory?
- Do any GitLab channel and/or alliance partners have relationships that the team may be able to leverage with a co-selling strategy/approach?
- Is the team aware of any key contacts who plan to retire or leave the company soon? If yes, what is their succession plan (so the team can proactively begin to engage with whomever will be assuming new responsibilities and influence)?

White Space Mapping

This is the part of the account plan where account teams seek to understand and document the customer's technology stack as it relates to how they develop and deploy applications and begin to identify where and how GitLab can deliver value. This mapping can be done for each discrete buying center or line of business within an account and/or at an aggregate account-level view.

1. Start by identifying what vendor technologies are used across each stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle, how that aligns to the customer's use case, and how the customer develops and deploys applications
1. Seek to understand what the customer would like to improve with how they develop and deploy applications and why
 - Do they want/need to accelerate their software delivery process? Reduce costs? Mitigate security and compliance risk? Other?
 - By how much?
 - What would it mean to the organization if they were to achieve these improvements? What are the implications if they fail to do so?
 - What is getting in the way of achieving these goals?
1. Engage in a discovery dialogue to identify positive business outcomes the organization hopes to achieve and the gap between their current state of operations and their desired future state.
1. Once you've earned the customer's trust, try to determine what the customer likes and dislikes about each of the vendor technologies currently being utilized, their annual investment with each vendor, when those contracts are up for renewal, etc.

With this understanding, you can begin to formulate a strategy for where and how GitLab can streamline the customer's DevSecOps adoption journey in pursuit of achieving their positive business outcomes. The pace of adoption within and across lines of business will vary from customer to customer, and the account plan identifies the strategic objectives and supporting actions that facilitate this adoption and growth. This plan will be supported by one or more opportunity plans when the customer allocates budget to a defined purchase initiative (at which point a Command Plan should be developed to support each unique opportunity).

Action Plan

This is the most important part of the account plan! Once the AE and the team plan the work, be sure to work the plan! Account plans are meaningless if there is no clear plan of action for achieving the objectives. Once the AE and the team identify a prioritized set of objectives that will help the team deliver more value to the customer in support of the customer's strategic business initiatives, begin to identify and assign action items that will enable the team to achieve each objective. An action plan should clearly document the following:

1. What is each team member trying to achieve?
1. How will each team member achieve success?
1. Who is taking the action?
1. What is the timeline for completing the action?
1. What resources or support are needed

Be sure to communicate and socialize the action plan with your account team to ensure alignment and understanding. Schedule periodic check-ins to drive accountability in execution.

Lastly, one of the fundamental benefits of an account plan is to figure out what you don't know and what you need to learn, so iterating frequently on the plan will help identify and address gaps. This will put you in a much better position to make decisions and take actions which will lead to success.

Building the Account Plan

Step 1: Account Prioritization

Rather than building an account plan for each and every one of your accounts, it is recommended that you prioritize your accounts with a process sometimes called Territory Planning. Ideally, focus your efforts on building up to three account plans at one time. A limited number of thoughtful and robust account plans for the most strategic accounts is a much better approach than spreading yourself too thin by trying to create, manage, and maintain a large number of account plans.

Step 2: Build the Account Profile

Invest time in researching the customer and gathering data and insights. Document what you know about the account and try to answer the questions outlined in the Account Profile section above. Identify and work on closing information gaps with your team until you have enough information to formulate a strategy.

Step 3: Relationship & White Space Mapping

Collaborate with your account team to conduct this analysis. Discuss the implications of the team's observations and insights from this exercise. Identify and prioritize what additional information is needed to fill in gaps and help inform your account strategy.

Step 4: Define Strategic Objectives

Based on the information gathered, work with your account team to define a short and a long term 'vision' for the account. Even better, do this with your customer (or share your plan and solicit feedback). A good place to start is with a 6 month plan. You can start by asking the customer: "Where do you want to be in the next year as it pertains to your DevSecOps maturity and implementation?" Take that answer and continue to ask the question in different ways to drive to clarity with the customer. Sometimes we might have to push the customer to think about things in a fresh way. Based on this, identify and prioritize 2-3 objectives that will improve your position in and/or understanding of the account and/or that support the customer's strategic business initiatives.

Samples

The one year vision:

The Customer says..."In the next year, the business will be ·."

- "To get there, the business will need to·."
- "Software development will play the role of·."
- "Our software teams will need to be able to·."
- "Our use of GitLab to support this will be·."
- "To get to that stage with GitLab, we will need to do·."
- "How we do that, is something · will need to own on our side"

Build out a plan of required capabilities, prioritize them, and then order them.

Some examples:

- In the next year, the business will be operating in 6 new countries, with 2 new product lines.
- To get there the business will need to hire new talent, we will need to build the products, we will need to open 6 new regional entities. We will also need to ensure that we are not over-extending the core profit making part of the business.
- Software development's role will be: 1) the products will be either fully or partially digital; 2) to launch the new product lines, in the new markets we wish to enter, will require new technical expertise in· AI/robotics/VR etc; 3) dev will need to ensure that the core cash-cow products at least keep their current margins while reducing cost.

Step 5: Document and Begin Executing the Action Plan

See the Action Plan section above for details. When the team is ready, share the plan with your manager and confirm next steps, resources needed, and review any information that is unclear. If appropriate, share the plan with partners to ensure alignment and commitment.

Step 6: Review, Monitor and Iterate

Account plans are living documents and are never truly complete. Plans will continue to evolve,

and the account team should continue to iterate on them. Once you build the initial plan ask yourself and the team:

- How can we determine the validity of the plan?
- What can we measure?
- Have I verified my understanding with my champion?

If a Customer Success Manager is assigned to this customer, check in with them on their Success Plan and ask if they are planning any Executive Business Reviews. These documents can help validate the account plan and determine if the vision is aligned with each customer's goals.

A quarterly cadence to review and update plans can help to ensure that plans reflect our current understanding of the account and keep the account team aligned on plan strategy and execution. Major changes such as personnel changes, mergers/aquisitions, and competitive threats may trigger immediate review and updates. Structured review sessions can help keep the account team aligned and keep leadership informed of changes involving customers.

Additional Considerations

- Account plans should be thoughtful, collaborative, and cross-functional with contributions and input from the entire account team including Solutions Architects, Customer Success Managers, Sales Leadership, Renewal Managers, Partners, and more
- Account plans are living documents, and a customer's business and strategies are always subject to change; share the account plan with the account team regularly to maintain a fresh understanding of the customer's needs and to keep everyone informed and aligned
- Account reps should use QBRs and/or other recurring meetings such as AE-SA-RM-CSM calls to review progress, update objectives and/or action plans, and align on next steps
- If you would like to work with your customer to build an account plan, there is a GoogleSlide Template you can print out and bring to the customer meeting to work on together.
- Review the below ten reasons why strategic plans fail according to this Forbes article and take proactive steps to avoid these pitfalls
 1. Having a plan simply for plan's sake
 1. Not understanding the environment or focusing on results
 1. Partial commitment
 1. Not having the right people involved
 1. Writing the plan and putting it on the shelf
 1. Unwillingness or inability to change
 1. Overcomplication the plan (inspired from this article)
 1. Ignoring marketplace reality, facts, and assumptions
 1. No accountability or follow through
 1. Unrealistic goals or lack of focus and resources

SECTION: sales/account-planning/coaching-for-asms.md

Overview

It is essential that Area Sales Managers (ASMs) support the Account Planning and Gainsight initiative with their teams. Below are the key messages that will need to be reinforced.

Key Messaging

- Account Planning helps to ensure all Account Executives (AEs) are successful in reaching their Peak Performance each and every year!
- Account Plans should be created for all key accounts as a minimum expectation. (Please refer to your regional guidance for what is defined as a key account in your patch)
- If an Account Plan is not already in place, then it should be created by the end of Stage 1 - Discovery (exit stage criteria).

What to Look for in a Great Account Plan

While there is no such thing as a "complete" account plan, there are things the ASM can look for that could indicate a plan is on the right track. Remember, we want to encourage thoughtful planning, NOT compliance. This is not a check the box activity, but a process/tool that will facilitate collaboration, strategic thinking and execution.

A common theme across all of the account planning components is collaboration. At every stage, verify that the AE is working with the Solutions Architect, Customer Success Manager, Renewals Manager and Channel and Alliances Partners. Be sure to ask follow up questions to understand how they are working with their teams and ensure that partners are being leveraged.

One method for reviewing the account plan with the AE is to ask open-ended questions. The AEs should already be thinking about these questions and be able to speak to them in a 1:1.

More detailed information for each of the components is below.

Account Profile

The Account Profile will be a combination of existing information from Salesforce and information added by the AE. While many AEs probably have this information in their head, we want to ensure that it is accurately captured in Salesforce or in their account planning document. As the ASM, you'll want to verify the following questions can be answered by reviewing the account plan.

- What are the organization's goals and the prioritized strategic initiatives aligned to each goal? What value drivers are most important and why?
- What macro environment factors are affecting the organization (e.g. market conditions, competition, regulatory and compliance changes, etc.) and what impact and implications do these factors have on the organization's business strategy?
- Who are the organization's primary competitors and how does the organization plan to maintain and/or grow market share?
- What are the biggest risks facing the organization (for short, medium, and longer term time horizons) that may get in the way of the customer achieving their goals?
- How does the organization's IT department and/or strategy support (or hinder) the above strategic objectives or initiatives?
- What is the organization's digital transformation strategy and how does that support the strategic business objectives?
- How does the customer currently view GitLab? How long have they been a customer? What is their annual spend with GitLab?

Relationship and Influence Mapping

Relationships are critical to discovering customer pain and being able to position GitLab as a solution. This section of the account plan is important, and you'll want to work with your AEs to ensure they are multi-threading across key contacts in the account (both within and across lines of business) and that they understand how different parts of the organization engage with and/or influence each other? Bear in mind that influence can be independent of the reporting structure.

Did the AE identify...

- The champions and key influencers?
 - Does the AE or someone else on the team have access to these people?
- Which contacts are promoters, detractors, or somewhere in between?
 - Who and what has influence over key contacts in the account (e.g. specific analysts, partners, events, trade publications, user groups, others)
- The strength or health of key relationships?

Whitespace Mapping

Start by verifying that the AE identified which vendor technologies are used across each stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle and how the customer develops and deploys applications.

Going beyond this, did the AE...

- Seek to understand what the customer would like to improve with how they develop and deploy applications and why?
- Identify what the customer wants/needs to accelerate their software delivery process? Reduce costs? Mitigate security and compliance risk?
- Identify what it would mean to the organization if they were to achieve these improvements? What are the implications if they fail to do so?
- Engage in a discovery dialogue (with the customer, SA, CSM, RM, or partner) to identify positive business outcomes the organization hopes to achieve and the gap between their current state of operations and their desired future state?
- Identify the customer's likes and dislikes about each of the vendor technologies currently being utilized, their annual investment with each vendor, and when those contracts are up for renewal?

Action Plan

The Action Plan is arguably the most important component of the Account Plan.

Does the plan answer the following questions?

- What are you trying to achieve in the next 6 months?
- How you will achieve success?
- Who is taking the action?
 - Does everyone on the team have an action item to work towards?
- What is the timeline for completing the action?
- What resources or support are needed for success?

SECTION: sales/club/index.md

See more about GitLab President's Club Handbook in the internal handbook.

SECTION: sales/command-of-the-message/_index.md

Overview

GitLab has adopted and operationalized Force Management's Command of the Message value-based sales messaging methodology. Due to IP constraints, we have migrated content from this page to GitLab's internal Handbook. GitLab team members may access additional content and resources on the Command of the Message Internal GitLab Handbook page (note: if you are a GitLab team member and cannot access the internal Handbook, please sign into the GitLab Internal Handbook app via Okta).

Customer Value Drivers

Value drivers describe what organizations are likely proactively looking for or needing and are top-of-mind customer topics that exist even if GitLab doesn't. Value drivers may cause buyers to re-allocate discretionary funds, and they support a value-based customer conversation. Organizations adopt and implement GitLab for the following value drivers:

- 1. Increase Operational Efficiencies - Simplify the software development toolchain to reduce total cost of ownership
- 1. Deliver Better Products Faster - Accelerate the software delivery process to meet business objectives
- 1. Reduce Security and Compliance Risk - Simplify processes to comply with internal processes, controls and industry regulations without compromising speed
- 1. Accelerate Cloud Adoption & Transformation - Standardize cloud processes to accelerate business outcomes

GitLab Differentiators

| GitLab Differentiator | Description |

| ----- | ----- |

| Single Application for Entire DevOps Lifecycle | - Complete DevSecOps platform delivered as a single application
 - One interface, one user-model, one data model
 - A software "factory" that supports the entire DevOps lifecycle
 - Deeply integrated, making developers happier and more efficient
 - Centralized collaboration for a wide variety of roles (collaborate without waiting) |

| AI-powered workflows across the SDLC | - AI-powered workflows through the entire SDLC, not just code, to create software faster, remove inefficiencies, & iterate rapidly |

| Leading SCM and CI / CD in One Application | - The backbone of a DevOps toolchain in one application
 - Streamlines code review and collaboration
 - Start with SCM or CI (or both)
 - One interface, one user-model, one data model
 - Interoperable with other tools (continue using tools you love!)
 - Proven enterprise scale |

| Built In Security and Compliance | - Security features out-of-the-box (code scanning, dependency scanning, secrets detection, etc.)
 - Automated security testing and audit controls to facilitate policy compliance
 - Shift left: move security testing earlier in the development lifecycle; security testing at the point of code commit
 - Developers get immediate feedback about new vulnerabilities they introduce
 - Enables better collaboration between development and security teams
 - One interface, one user-model, one data model for DevSecOps |

| Built to Scale | - GitLab allows for horizontal scaling to 50k+ users using documented reference architectures
 - GitLab's single DevSecOps platform allows organizations to know how their costs will increase as they grow
 - GitLab gives the ability to plan across the entire organization |

| Deploy Your Software Anywhere | - Deploy to any environment, any cloud
 - Support for GCP, AWS, Azure, OpenShift, VMWare, On Prem, Bare Metal, etc.
 - Workflow portability: one deployment workflow regardless of destination |

| Optimized for Kubernetes | - Enables adoption of modern cloud-native development patterns such as microservices and serverless
 - Minimizes the Kubernetes learning curve by enabling setup and use of clusters from the GitLab user interface
 - View and manage Kubernetes deployment pod details and logs from the GitLab user interface
 - Automatic monitoring of every Kubernetes deployed application and the clusters they are deployed to
 - Built-in canary and incremental deployment strategies with automatic canary metric collection and display
 - Active contributor to the future of cloud native technologies (through the Cloud Native Computing Foundation) |

| End-to-End Insight and Built-In Value Stream Management | - Common data model uniquely allows for insights across the entire DevSecOps lifecycle
 - Configurable insights dashboard that shows status of work items over time
 - Cycle analytics data helps identify areas of improvement of cycle times
 - Security insights provide a roll-up of vulnerabilities
 - Program level insights help keep projects on-track |

| Flexible GitLab Hosting Options | - Use in the cloud or install in your own environment (cloud or on-prem)
 - Feature parity between GitLab.com and self-managed
 - Migrate from one hosting option to another when needs change
 - Implement hybrid hosting models to support scaling (like CI Runners in the cloud)
 - Easy to upgrade and maintain in any environment |

| Rapid Innovation | - Releases every month, for 100+ months running
 - A constant stream of new features -> GitLab gets more valuable over time
 - Uniquely transparent product development process; customers, partners and community can contribute |

| Open Source; Everyone Can Contribute | - Open core development model allows anyone to contribute to the functionality of the product
 - Uniquely transparent product development process engaging customers, partners and the community
 - Strong and growing community (100K+ organizations and millions of users)
 - Harness open source innovations within the product experience (e.g. Prometheus) |

| Collaborative and Transparent Customer Experience | - We operationalize our core values into how we develop our product and engage with our community and customers
 - Extreme transparency around roadmaps, issues, company meetings and processes
 - We use GitLab for collaborating with customers in a transparent way, for both issue resolution and roadmap iteration
 - GitLab provides an evolving case study of DevSecOps and agile practices at scale, accessible through the public handbook |

SECTION: sales/command-of-the-message/command-plan.md

Overview

The Command Plan is how GitLab has operationalized Command of the Message (a customer value-driven sales methodology) and MEDDPICC (a proven methodology used for strategic opportunity management and complex sales process orchestration for enterprise organizations) into the opportunity management process. Access the Effective Command Plans to Help You Win More Deals e-learning course for ENT or Strategic Opportunity Management for Commercial.

Command Plan Requirements

The Command Plan consists of the below 3 sections. The Opportunity Overview section is required for ALL opportunities in stage 2-Scoping or later for current quarter and next quarter as a minimum global standard. The remaining sections (MEDDPICC and Close Plan Details) are only required for opportunities at or above defined ARR thresholds (\$100K+ for Enterprise, \$50K+ for Mid-Market).

By day 1 of the current quarter, all Command Plans and Opportunity Consults should be updated for both the current and next quarters. Note: These thresholds are minimum global standards, and geographic and segment specific teams can and should aim to exceed these expectations by extending the command plan process to lower deal thresholds where appropriate.

1. Opportunity Overview

1. MEDDPICC

1. Close Plan Details

At the sales level, the Command Plan is owned by the Strategic Account Executive or Commercial Account Executive who creates the plan and updates the contents accordingly. It is used as a living pre-sales document, and its objectives are converted into Gainsight Success Plan objectives at the time of account onboarding.

You can find the Command Plan button in the Opportunity Detail section of the Salesforce opportunity object (see image below) or in Clari or in the top right dropdown menu on the Opportunity Record in Salesforce Lightning. Please note that Command Plans are capped at 5000 characters in Salesforce to encourage sales team members to be crisp and succinct. To do so, the Command Plan should focus on future-looking plans and remove details that are no longer relevant to the current close plan. For information you'd like to remove from the Command Plan but keep for historical purposes, please add that information as a new activity record on the opportunity.

Opportunity Overview

This section consists of 5 mandatory fields:

1. Why Now? - What is the compelling event? Why does the customer need to make the purchase now including both qualitative and quantitative implications?

1. Primary Value Driver - What is the primary business problem that the customer is trying to solve (even if GitLab didn't exist) that is causing the economic buyer to allocate discretionary funds to solve?

1. Solution - What is the primary GitLab solution (Automate Software Delivery, Continuous Software Security Assurance, Software Compliance, or DevOps Platform) that best aligns with the problem the customer wants to solve?

1. Primary Capability - What is the primary capability that the customer is pursuing to achieve the above value driver(s)?

1. Why GitLab? - Why is the customer choosing GitLab over the competition? What are GitLab's key differentiators from the customer's perspective?

1. Why Do Anything At All? - What are the negative consequences if the customer does nothing? What happens if the customer doesn't do this deal on the forecasted timeline?

MEDDPPICC

There are a total of 9 MEDDPPICC fields (see details here).

Close Plan Details

This section is comprised of the following 3 fields:

1. Close Plan - What is the full beginning to end close plan with dates (day by day or week by week)?

1. Risks - What is the biggest risk with this opportunity? What would be the possible reasons for why the deal doesn't come in on time? What are we doing to proactively address and/or mitigate key risks?

1. Help - How can the extended GitLab team help (i.e. Product Management/Engineering needs, Legal requirements, Deal Desk, Finance, Execs)?

Manager Review

Continuing to improve the fidelity of Command Plans is a critical success factor to winning more deals and improving productivity and predictability. As such, at the bottom of the Command Plan is a section for Managers and above to enter review notes from opportunity consults (and/or Lightweight Deal Reviews for Commercial Sales) conducted. Manager Review notes should begin with "YYYY-MM-DD" to indicate the date when the opportunity consult was conducted, and the notes should succinctly highlight:

1. Prioritized gaps identified during the opportunity consult

1. Specific action items that were agreed to (who will do what by when)

Note: The Manager Review Info section (immediately below the Manager Review section) will auto-populate based on information entered in the Manager Review section.

Enterprise Area Sales Manager Expectat